NIGHT 30 — THE PACK MOVES ON WROUGHTWOOD

The hard deadline. Regardless of every choice, every thread, every relationship built or burned — the pack comes on Night 30. What Marcus has prepared determines what he can do when they arrive.

HATTIE'S WOLFSBANE — Pre-Endgame Item

Available: Day 25+ if HATTIE_ALIVE and HATTIE_REL not hostile **Trigger:** Hattie finds Marcus before he goes out on one of the final nights

She meets him at the foot of the stairs. In her hands — a bundle of dried stems, gray-green, tied with kitchen twine. She holds it out.

"My grandmother grew this in the back garden," she says. *"And her mother before her. I always kept it going because she told me to. Never asked why."*

She looks at the bundle.

"I think I know why now."

She doesn't say what she thinks she knows. She doesn't ask Marcus to confirm it. She just holds it out and waits for him to take it.

When he does she nods once — the nod of a woman completing something that has been waiting to be completed for a long time — and goes back to the kitchen.

WOLFSBANE_OBTAINED set Inventory item: Wolfsbane Bundle — 3 uses

Mechanical Effect:

- Applied to a weapon or thrown directly — werewolf contact causes WOLFSBANE_BURN status: Defense -4, Attack Mod -3, movement slowed for 2 rounds
- Has no effect on Marcus himself
- 3 uses total — each use consumes one-third of the bundle
- Hattie's grandmother knew. Hattie's grandmother was ready. The line of women who kept this garden stretches back further than anyone in Wroughtwood has examined.

THE TOWN — Night 30, Opening

Wroughtwood does not know what is coming.

The evening is ordinary — smoke from chimneys, the inn's light on, Calhoun's store dark and locked, the church quiet. Whatever has been happening in the north woods for thirty days has been absorbed by the town the way Wroughtwood absorbs everything: by not looking at it directly and continuing to function.

The moon is full.

It has been climbing all evening — Marcus has felt it the way he has felt every moon phase for thirty days, but this is different. This is the moon at its complete and total worst, pulling at everything the wolf is, turning the hunger into a roar and the rage into something structural. He has been managing it since sundown. His hands are steady. His jaw is tight. He is holding.

Cord chose this night deliberately. He has watched thirty cycles of the full moon from those woods. He knows what it does to new infections. He knows what Marcus is fighting inside himself right now.

He chose tonight because Marcus is already halfway gone before the first wolf clears the tree line.

The first sound is not screaming. It is the dogs — every dog in Wroughtwood going silent at the same moment, the particular silence of animals that have registered something and chosen not to antagonize it. That silence spreads across the town like a held breath.

Then the tree line moves.

ENDGAME PATH SPLIT

PATH A — MARCUS JOINED THE PACK

Condition: PACK_MEMBER set

Marcus is in the north woods when the pack assembles. He has been here. He knows the shape of what's about to happen — the lieutenants coordinating, the pack body moving to positions, Cord standing at the tree line's edge looking at Wroughtwood with a century of patience about to end.

He has until the pack crosses the tree line to decide.

THE INSIDE TURN — Betraying the Pack

The pack moves and Marcus moves with them — toward the tree line, toward town, in the rhythm he has learned over the days since joining. Nobody is watching him specifically. He is pack. He belongs here.

He stops at the tree line.

The pack flows around him. Curtis passes close — if alive, Curtis looks at him once. Something in Curtis's expression. He knows. He doesn't stop moving.

Cord is at the far end of the line. His pale eyes find Marcus across the dark.

He stops.

He looks at Marcus standing still while the pack moves.

The town is ahead. Lights in windows. People who don't know.

[PLAYER CHOICE — The Last Moment]

A — Turn on the pack Marcus transforms. Not a blackout — a choice. The first fully voluntary transformation in the game. He chooses it, controls it, and steps in front of the pack's advance.

What follows is the hardest combat sequence in the game. Marcus against pack members he has run with — wolves he knows the movement patterns of, wolves who know his. The wolfsbane if he has it. His thirty days of built ability. Everything.

The pack doesn't want to kill Marcus — Cord wants him, the pack bond runs both directions. But they will incapacitate him if they can.

PACK_BETRAYED set **See: ENDGAME RESOLUTION — THE ALPHA FIGHT**

B — Complete the attack Marcus crosses the tree line with the pack.

PACK_LOYAL set **See: ENDING — THE GENERAL'S ARMY**

PATH B — MARIE'S PLAN

Condition: MARIE_FORMALLY_MET + TRUST_MARIE 8+ + MARIE_WITHDRAWN NOT set OR repaired

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THE PLAN — Usurping Cord

Marie does not want to destroy the pack. She wants to redirect it. A pack without Cord's century-old obsession with Wroughtwood is a pack that can be managed — pointed away, kept deep in the north woods, contained by the threshold rather than spilling over it.

The plan requires Marcus to challenge Cord directly. Pack law — older than Wroughtwood, older than Cord himself, built into the infection's structure by the spirit that created it — recognizes a successful challenge as a transfer of alpha status. Defeat Cord, become alpha. The pack follows strength. It has no choice.

Marie's role: keep the pack off Marcus while he fights Cord. She cannot fight Cord herself — something about the nature of what the spirit made will not yield to what she is. But she can hold the others.

"This land was a threshold between states," she told Marcus during the planning. *"Between human and not. Between what a person is and what they can become. Cord has been using that — turning it outward, toward the town."* She looked at the fire. *"If you stand at that threshold and you win — you become the direction the pack faces. You can turn them inward. Back into the woods."*

"And if I lose?"

She looked at him.

"Then I was wrong about you."

NIGHT 30 — MARIE'S ENDGAME

Marcus is at the north woods boundary when the pack assembles to move on town. He is not hiding. He is standing in the pack's path.

The pack stops.

Cord sees him. The pale eyes across the dark. He doesn't move immediately. He reads the situation — the way a general reads a tactical development, assessing variables.

Then from the swamp behind Marcus: Marie. Standing at the tree line's edge, the swamp at her back, her hands open at her sides. The willows are moving though there is no wind.

The pack registers her. Several members step back without deciding to.

Cord looks at Marcus.

"You chose a side," he says. The West Point voice. Flat with something that might be satisfaction — a century-old general who has finally gotten a worthy problem. *"I wondered if you would."*

"I chose," Marcus says.

THE FIGHT — MARCUS VS CORD

This is the final boss encounter.

Cord transforms fully for the first time Marcus has seen it — the shift from the man-shape to something eight feet of silver-gray, bipedal, wrong in all the ways Marcus has learned and wrong in several new ways. He is larger than any other pack member by a measure that is not incidental. A century of alpha has accumulated in his body the way authority accumulates in some men — visibly, structurally, undeniably.

He does not rush. He never rushes. He has been patient for a hundred years.

While Marcus fights Cord — Marie holds the pack.

The pack tries to intervene. They cannot reach Marcus. The swamp has come — not physically, but as an extension of Marie, vines and roots and water moving through the north woods soil, the threshold itself responding to her direction. Pack members that advance find the ground uncertain. Find the dark uncertain. Find something looking at them from the tree shadows that is not Marcus and is not Cord and is very old.

They hold.

CORD COMBAT STATS

Stat	Value
HP	150
Attack Mod	+8
Defense	18
Damage Die	d12
Special Ability 1	**Command Presence** — once per 3 rounds, Cord issues a challenge. Marcus must roll HUMANITY check (d20 + HUMANITY/10) vs 16 or lose his next action — the pack bond pulling at him
Special Ability 2	**Alpha's Endurance** — when Cord drops below 75 HP he enters a second phase. Defense drops to 15 but Attack Mod increases to +10 and damage die becomes d12+4
Special Ability 3	**Century's Weight** — on a natural 20 attack roll, Cord pins Marcus. Automatic 20 damage, Marcus loses one round breaking free

FULL MOON MODIFIERS — Active for all Night 30 combat:

- RAGE starts at 60 minimum going into any fight — the moon has been building it since sundown
- HUNGER starts at 70 minimum — the wolf is loud and has been loud for hours
- **HUMANITY CHECK required at the start of each combat wave** — d20 + (HUMANITY/10) vs 12. Fail: RAGE +10 before the wave begins, one less action available first round
- **Silver:** Darnell's blade if he's still in play, Harlan's rounds — both more dangerous tonight. LUPINE_BURN damage doubled on full moon.
- **Wolfsbane effectiveness increases** — full moon heightens wolf biology in every direction. WOLFSBANE_BURN duration extends to 3 rounds per use instead of 2.
- **Marie's Protection Bundle** if MARIE_GIFT_RECEIVED — RAGE cap holds at 80 regardless of moon. The single most valuable item in the endgame.

CORD — SECOND PHASE NARRATION

When Cord drops below 75 HP something changes in the clearing.

He stops moving.

He looks at Marcus — really looks, the way he looked from the rise on the first observation night — and something in his face reorganizes. Not fear. A general recalibrating.

"You're not what I expected," he says. Still the West Point voice. Slightly ragged now, slightly present in a way it wasn't before — like the fight is waking something up in him. *"Most of them — when they come here — they want to be told what to do. They want the ceiling gone."*

He moves.

"You're trying to put the ceiling back."

He hits harder in the second phase. He is trying to end it quickly now — patience replaced with the particular efficiency of a professional who has determined that this is the moment.

Marcus has to weather it. Hold. Find the opening.

CORD DEFEATED

He goes down slowly — not like a person falling, like a structure failing. The immense body folding at specific points, the pale eyes tracking Marcus all the way to the ground.

He does not transform back. He is what he is. He lies in the clearing's dirt and breathes — ragged, massive, the silver-gray fur dark with exertion.

He looks at Marcus.

"Well," he says.

Just that. A general conceding a field.

[PLAYER CHOICE — Cord's fate]

A — Let him live as a subordinate The pack bond shifts. Marcus can feel it — the pack's orientation changing like a compass needle finding new north. Cord feels it too. His eyes close briefly. *"I have not taken orders in a hundred years,"* he says. *"You have now,"* Marcus says. Cord is silent for a long time. *"Yes,"* he says. *"I have now."* CORD_SUBORDINATE set — Cord lives. The pack has a new alpha. The oldest, most dangerous wolf in the north woods is now below Marcus in the order. What that means going forward is something Marcus will spend the rest of his life navigating.

B — End it A hundred years is a long time to be what Cord became. Marcus makes the decision that the spirit should have made a century ago. What happens is between Marcus and Cord and the clearing. The pack goes still when it's done. Then — slowly, disoriented — they begin to scatter. Without Cord's century-old direction the pack bond weakens. Not gone. But without an alpha it fragments. CORD_DEAD set. PACK_FRAGMENTING set. Marcus stands in the clearing. He is the alpha of a fragmenting pack in the north woods of a town that is on fire in the distance. He has thirty minutes before dawn.

MARIE — AFTER THE FIGHT

She comes from the tree line when it's done. She looks at Cord — living or dead — and then at Marcus with an expression that has several things in it that she does not separate out for him.

She touches his face briefly. One hand. Warm.

"Alpha," she says. Testing the word.

Then she steps back.

"Now we turn them north," she says. *"Away from the town. Away from the road. Deep enough that they find their own country."*

She looks at Marcus.

"Can you do that?"

The pack is around them in the dark. Waiting.

Marcus raises his head and does something with his voice that is not a howl and is not a word — something in the frequency between those things that thirty days of the wolf have built in him. The pack responds. Not all of them. Most of them. They orient. They begin to move — north, deeper, away from the lights of Wroughtwood.

Cord moves with them if alive. He does not look back.

LEADS TO: ENDING — ALPHA OF THE NORTH

PATH C — TAKODA'S CLEANSING

Condition: RESTORATION_POSSIBLE + TAKODA_MET all 6 visits + WOLFSBANE_OBTAINED recommended

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THE PREPARATION

Takoda has been collecting what he needs for decades — materials, knowledge, the specific understanding of where the boundary markers stood and what they were made of. He cannot restore them alone. He is one old man and the pack is fifteen wolves and the alpha is a century of something that doesn't stop.

He needs Marcus. He needs the wolfsbane. He needs someone who can move through the pack's territory without being immediately destroyed — and ideally someone who can hold the wolves back while Takoda works.

"The markers must be replaced at seven specific points," he told Marcus during the final planning visit. *"I have the materials for each. I know the locations."* He looked at Marcus steadily. *"The pack will feel the first marker go in. After that — they will come."*

"How long do you need?"

"For all seven — an hour. Perhaps more."

Marcus looked at him.

"I'll hold them," he said.

Takoda was quiet for a long time.

"The cleansing will not distinguish," he said carefully. *"Between the spirit's plague and other presences on the land. Everything the spirit touched — or that operates on similar frequencies—"*

"Marie," Marcus said.

"I do not know for certain. I believe — yes."

Marcus sat with that.

"Does she know?"

"I did not tell her," Takoda said. *"I thought perhaps you should."*

TELLING MARIE — OR NOT

[PLAYER CHOICE — before Night 30]

A — Tell Marie She listens without interrupting. When Marcus finishes she is quiet for a long time. The fire between them.

"I know," she says finally. *"I have known since you first went to the old man."*

"Then—"

"I have been here a very long time, Marcus." She looks at the fire. *"Longer than you can hold in your head. Longer than this land has been what it is."* A pause. *"I have been many things in many places. I will be something somewhere else."*

She looks at him. Her eyes giving back more than they receive, the way they always have.

"Do what needs doing," she says. *"That is not a small thing — that you told me."*

She reaches into the folds of her wrap and sets something on the ground between them. A small bound bundle — different from the wolfsbane, darker, tied with red cord.

"For the fight," she says. *"It will help you hold."*

MARIE_TOLD_CLEANSING set MARIE_GIFT_RECEIVED set — **Protection Bundle: RAGE cannot exceed 80 during the cleansing fight. The wolf is present but Marcus stays Marcus.** HUMANITY +15 — the hardest kind of honesty.

B — Don't tell Marie MARIE_NOT_TOLD set — she will find out when the cleansing happens. She will not be able to say goodbye. What she does with that — whether she appears in the aftermath, what she says — will depend on the relationship built across thirty days.

NIGHT 30 — TAKODA'S ENDGAME

Takoda moves at dusk. He knows the seven locations by memory and by the particular quality of the ground at each one — places where the earth still remembers what stood there. He moves north as the pack assembles to move south.

Marcus moves between them.

The first marker goes into the ground at 9pm. The sound it makes is not a sound — it is a frequency, a change in the air, a tuning of something that has been out of tune for over a century. The pack feels it.

They turn.

THE HOLDING — Combat Gauntlet

Marcus must hold the pack back across seven marker placements. Each placement is a wave. Each wave is harder than the last as the pack grows more desperate — the land itself closing around them, the threshold reasserting, the old control coming back one marker at a time.

WAVE STRUCTURE:

Wave	Marker	Enemies	Special Condition
1	Marker 1	2 pack body	Standard — Marcus gets his footing
2	Marker 2	3 pack body	One has been infected 20+ years — harder, faster
3	Marker 3	3 pack body + 1 lieutenant	First lieutenant encounter
4	Marker 4	4 pack body	WOLFSBANE_BURN available — recommended here
5	Marker 5	2 pack body + 2 lieutenants	Jacob Marsh is one of the lieutenants
6	Marker 6	Full pack body (8)	Swarm encounter — Marcus must survive, not win
7	Marker 7	**CORD**	Final encounter — see below

Jacob Marsh — Wave 5: If MARSH_JACOB_IN_PACK known — Marcus recognizes Jacob in the fight. The compass in his pocket points directly at Jacob during the encounter.

[PLAYER CHOICE — mid-combat]

- **Fight Jacob like the others** — Jacob is defeated or driven back with the wave.
- **Stop fighting** — Hold ground, don't advance. Jacob stops too. Something in the pack bond recognizes the hesitation. He withdraws from the wave without fully committing. JACOB_SPARED set — when the cleansing completes, Jacob is among those who reverts.

CORD — FINAL WAVE

Takoda places the seventh marker. His hands are steady. He has been waiting for this moment for decades and he performs it with the care of someone who is not going to rush the last thing.

The seventh marker enters the earth.

The land *exhales.*

Cord comes through the trees alone. The pack behind him has stopped — the threshold reasserting around them, the boundary markers completing the circuit, the old control locking into place. They cannot advance further. The land itself is holding them.

Cord can still advance. He is the oldest. He is the deepest rooted. The spirit's first work is also its most durable.

He transforms fully — the eight-foot silver-gray shape, the pale eyes, the West Point bearing somehow intact even in this — and looks at Marcus.

And Takoda, behind Marcus, straightens from placing the final marker and looks at Cord with the expression of a man completing a task he has been building toward his entire life.

"This land remembers," Takoda says quietly. Not to Cord. To the land itself.

Cord and Marcus fight.

Same combat stats as PATH B. Same second phase. Same resolution choices.

DIFFERENCE: If MARIE_GIFT_RECEIVED — RAGE cap at 80. Marcus stays himself throughout. The fight is controlled. He is choosing every move.

THE CLEANSING — After Cord

When Cord falls the land finishes what the markers started.

It is not dramatic. There is no light, no sound, no visible manifestation. The threshold simply reasserts itself — the boundary the tribe maintained for generations, the line between states of being, back in its correct position. The spirit's alteration of the soldiers was never natural. The land knew that. It was waiting to be reminded.

The pack — caught within the boundary, the infection within the restored threshold — begins to revert.

Not all of them. The oldest infected are too far gone — the infection has been their state for so long that what was beneath it is no longer recoverable. They will continue as what they are, contained now within the north woods boundary, unable to cross the markers.

The more recent infections — Jacob Marsh if spared in Wave 5, others infected in the last few years — revert. They are found the next morning in the north woods, confused, human, with no memory of what they were.

Jacob Marsh walks out of the north woods at dawn.

He does not know where he has been for five years. He does not know his mother has been sitting in that house for five years with an empty box in the churchyard. He just walks south toward the lights of Wroughtwood on a road he hasn't seen since he was twenty-two years old.

JACOB_RETURNED set

MARIE — THE EXPULSION

Marcus feels it when it happens — a frequency going quiet that has been present since the first night he stood at her door. Not gone. *Away.* Moving south and then further south and then beyond what he can feel.

The cabin is still there. The fire has gone out. The bundles still hang from the eaves. The curtain at the back still moves in a draft from nowhere.

But she is gone.

If MARIE_TOLD_CLEANSING — on the ground in front of the extinguished fire, placed deliberately: the small bound bundle she gave Marcus for the fight, a second one he didn't see before, and a piece of dark fabric tied with red cord. Inside the fabric — nothing visible. But when Marcus holds it the threshold hums faintly and whatever the wolf is doing in him quiets. Not gone. Manageable. A parting gift from something older than the land that just expelled her.

She will be something somewhere else. She said that. She meant it.

If MARIE_NOT_TOLD — the cabin is simply empty. No note. No gift. The fire out and the door open and the swamp going back to being just a swamp.

MARIE_EXPELLED set HUMANITY — no change. Grief is not a stat modifier. It is just grief.

LEADS TO: ENDING — THE LAND REMEMBERS

THE ENDINGS

ENDING A — THE GENERAL'S ARMY

Trigger: PACK_LOYAL — Marcus crossed the tree line with the pack on Night 30

The attack on Wroughtwood takes most of the night.

Marcus is part of it. He does what the pack does. He is pack — fully, completely, the choice made and held.

By dawn Wroughtwood is changed. The people who could be taken were taken. The people who couldn't or wouldn't are gone another way. The town that has been absorbing violence quietly for a hundred years finally runs out of room to absorb it.

Marcus stands in the main road at sunrise. The pack around him. Cord at the center fire in the north woods, satisfied, a century of patience finally repaid.

He has become what Cord always intended him to be.

The compass — if he has it — is in his pocket. The needle spins once and stops pointing anywhere.

Fade to black.

The town of Wroughtwood disappears from county records in 1961. Officially: abandoned due to economic decline. No investigation.

The north woods remain.

ENDING: THE GENERAL'S ARMY *You had thirty days to decide what you were. You decided.*

ENDING B — ALPHA OF THE NORTH

Trigger: CORD_DEFEATED via Marie's plan, pack turned northward

The pack moves north. Marcus stands at the tree line and watches them go — deeper into the north woods, away from Wroughtwood, away from the road. Cord moving with them if alive, subordinate for the first time in a century. The wolves disappearing into the dark between the trees until the dark is just dark.

Marie stands beside him.

The town of Wroughtwood is intact behind them. Shaken — people heard things, some things happened at the edges — but standing. Pruitt will have questions in the morning. Calhoun, if alive, will have a theory. Hattie will make coffee and not say what she saw from the inn window.

Marie looks north where the pack went.

"They'll need managing," she says. *"Regularly. A pack without purpose becomes a problem."*

"I know."

"You'll need to go to them. Often." She looks at Marcus. *"You understand what that means. What you are now."*

"I understand."

She is quiet for a moment.

"You could leave," she says. *"Let them fragment. It would take years but eventually—"*

"No," Marcus says.

She looks at him. That expression — several things not separated.

"Non," she agrees quietly.

They stand at the tree line until the sky begins to lighten.

Fade to black.

Marcus Grave does not leave Wroughtwood. He is seen, occasionally, at the field's edge at dawn. The north woods stay quiet. Mostly.

ENDING: ALPHA OF THE NORTH *The land needed a keeper. You didn't apply for the job. You got it anyway.*

ENDING C — THE LAND REMEMBERS

Trigger: RESTORATION_POSSIBLE — Takoda's cleansing completed

Dawn comes over Wroughtwood. The boundary markers stand at seven points in the north woods, the threshold restored, the land doing what it was always meant to do.

Takoda sits at his fire. He has been at his fire since the last marker went in. He looks like a man who has finished something he was given to finish — not triumphant, not relieved exactly. Complete.

Marcus comes to him at dawn.

They sit together without speaking for a long time.

"The land will hold now," Takoda says finally. *"For a generation. Perhaps two. Then — the markers will need tending again. Someone will need to know."*

He looks at Marcus.

"You are infected," he says. *"The cleansing contained the pack. It did not cure you. The threshold's restoration means you can manage it — the boundary suppresses the wolf's worst impulses within this land."*

"So I stay," Marcus says.

"Or you go and come back," Takoda says. *"The markers need maintenance. The land needs someone who understands what it is."* A pause. *"The tribe tended it for generations. I am the last of them. I am also old."*

Marcus looks at the north woods. The boundary markers invisible from here but present — felt, the way the pull has always been felt.

Jacob Marsh is walking out of those woods right now. In the churchyard there is an empty box with his name on it. His mother has been sitting in that house for five years.

The compass in Marcus's pocket. The needle pointing south — away, open, the world past Wroughtwood still there.

[FINAL CHOICE]

A — Stay. Tend the land. Marcus puts the compass in his pocket and turns back toward the town. There are things that need to be said to people. Hattie. Pruitt. Maybe even Eleanor Marsh, when her son has been home long enough. And then there is work. Quiet, generational, unglamorous work. The same work the tribe did for centuries before anyone built a town on top of it. *He is twenty-five years old. He has time.*

B — Go. But come back. Marcus walks south on the dirt road out of Wroughtwood. Past the inn. Past Calhoun's store. Past the sign he read on his first morning. He goes as far as the road takes him and finds whatever is left of his life outside this place and tries to rebuild it around the thing he's carrying. He comes back six months later. Takoda is still at his fire. *"The east marker needs resetting,"* Takoda says, without looking up. Marcus crouches beside the fire. *"Show me,"* he says.

Fade to black.

The boundary holds. The north woods stay north. Wroughtwood endures — the way it has always endured. By not looking directly at what keeps it standing.

ENDING: THE LAND REMEMBERS *A hundred years of damage. Seven markers. One man who stayed.*

ENDINGS SUMMARY

Ending	Path	What Marcus Becomes	Town Survives
THE GENERAL'S ARMY	Pack loyal, joins attack	Cord's soldier	No
ALPHA OF THE NORTH	Marie's plan, defeats Cord	Pack alpha, guardian	Yes — barely
THE LAND REMEMBERS	Takoda's cleansing	Threshold keeper	Yes
GODDESS OF VOODOO (Companion)	Marie's thread, intervenes	Marie's equal	Unclear
GODDESS OF VOODOO (Pet)	Marie's thread, stands down	Marie's kept thing	Unclear
CONTAINED	Harlan's thread, full disclosure	Dominion's subject	Erased
CHAINS	Calhoun's thread, bad standing	Depends on resolution	Damaged

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SCENE NOTES

- **Jacob walking out of the north woods at dawn** in THE LAND REMEMBERS is the payoff of everything — Eleanor's five years, the compass, the churchyard box, Cade's broken faith, all of it converging on one man walking south through the trees toward his mother's house. The game doesn't show the reunion. It doesn't need to.
- **Cord subordinate in ALPHA OF THE NORTH** is the detail that should sit with the player long after the game ends. Marcus turned the pack north. Cord went. A hundred-year-old general taking orders from a twenty-five-year-old man who has been a werewolf for thirty days. The land did something stranger than anyone planned.
- **THE LAND REMEMBERS not curing Marcus** is the right call. The cleansing is for the land. Marcus carries what he carries. The boundary suppresses it, manages it, makes it livable — but it doesn't go away. He is still Marcus Grave. He is also still something else. Both things are true and will remain true.
- **Hattie's grandmother's wolfsbane** completing its purpose across generations without anyone understanding why until the moment it mattered is the quietest thread in the entire game. A woman who kept a garden because her grandmother told her to. The grandmother who knew. The line running backward into a history Wroughtwood has been pretending it doesn't have.
- **The compass pointing south in THE GENERAL'S ARMY** and stopping is the only time the compass fails. It was pointing toward what Marcus needed to find. When Marcus stops needing to find anything — when he has chosen to stop being the man who was looking — the compass has nothing left to do.